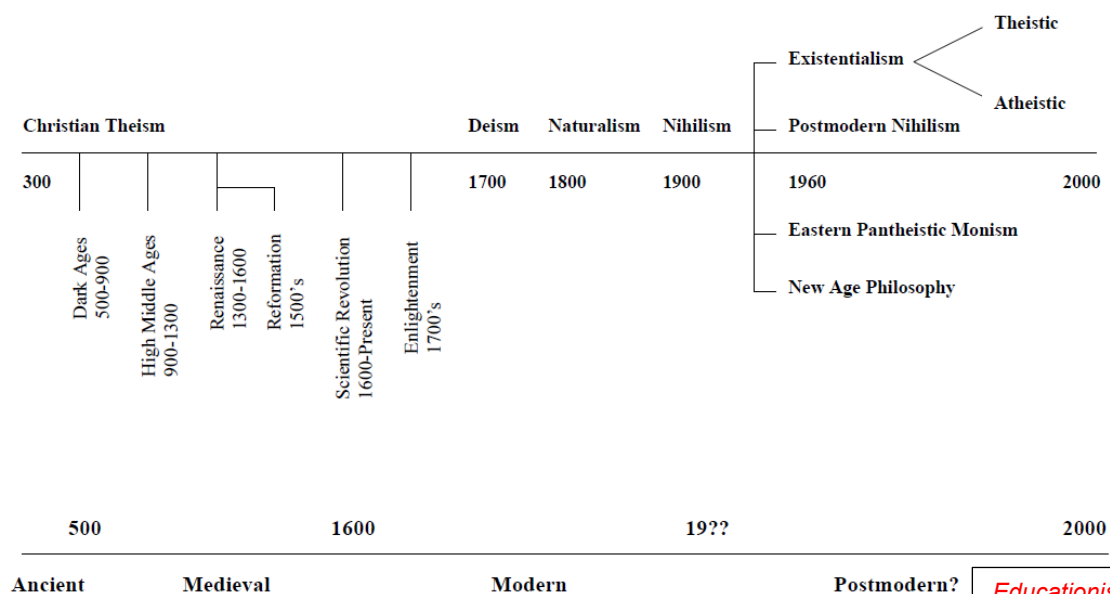


Postmodernism and Social justice

The following timeline depicts axiological revolutions across history, highlighting some of the major changes and shifts in history that also affected worldviews. Study this timeline along with Chapter 1 of the prescribed textbook to acknowledge the characteristic changes from traditionalism, modernism towards postmodernism.

WORLDVIEW HISTORY TIMELINE



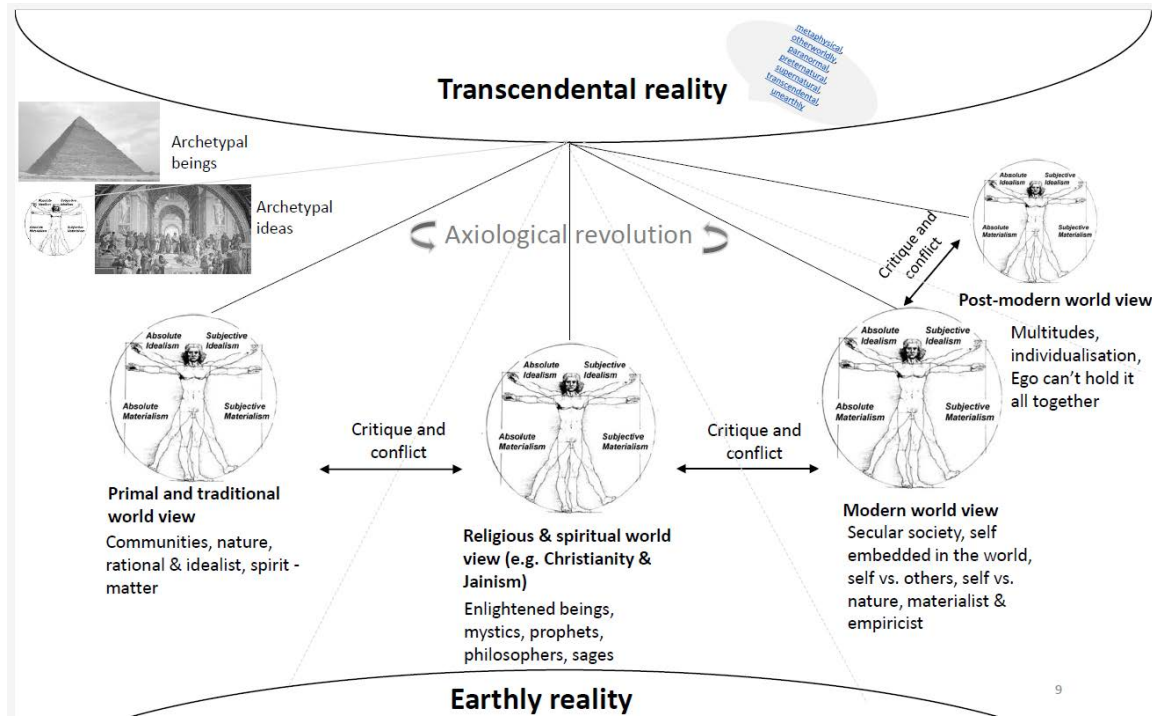
Educationists often address the schools as they were, not as they are...

Source:

<https://www.google.com/search?q=Time+line+of+worldviews&oq=Time+line+of+worldviews+&aqs=chrome..69i57j69i59l2.3159j0j4&sourceid=chrome&ie=UTF-8>

We live in an era towards the expression of consciousness, that is – we find ourselves at a place in time affected by the historical attitudes towards the world. Postmodernism asks us to look at the world again, so that we can see it the way it really is (or become).

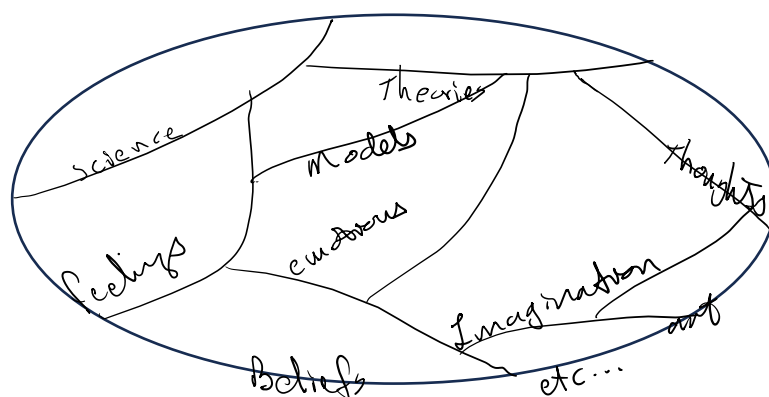
Modernism is founded on theories of aesthetic experience.



We know that the world of science organizes knowledge (or epistemology) around questions such as how knowledge came to exist - and consists of ideas, emotions, theories, feelings, models etc. - as types of knowing.

Epistemological boundaries

On a basic level, the following diagram shows epistemology divided by rules and principles from a modernist perspective. The areas that emerge as science, art, theories, models etc. make up the personal mental models of an individual that can be used to make sense of the world (in doing so, these knowledge structures help shape your worldview).



Epistemology can be considered as the limit of knowledge. The epistemological boundaries that you see between the fields of science and art (for instance) are created by the categorization and classification of knowledge structures, such as knowledge /awareness of feelings, emotions, theories, models, imagination etc.

The processes for categorization and classification are founded upon a scientific framework, that is the boundaries are created by scientific reasoning. Modernism is considered to hold theoretical and ideological assumptions about social, aesthetic, and political traditions. It refers to the possibilities of measurement, time, and reason to shape rationality and is oriented towards pragmatism – (measuring success in terms of achievement).

Boundaries produce metanarratives

Such categorizations and classifications produce narratives of an individual, often expressed in various forms of art and religion or symbols. When a group of these narratives are put together, such meta-narratives drive the religious beliefs of people, as these narratives explain the importance of the ideas that shaped them (for instance stories that are embedded within a religion share an attitude towards that religion). Postmodernism denies such metanarratives and rationalism. Postmodernism, rather, looks at reality as an extreme form of antirealism or socially constructed – that is – we are responsible for creating our own realities, thereby providing a critique against the boundaries that separate theories from beliefs developed based on real-world experiences.

Postmodernism is associated with the changing or challenging of these modernist structures (also see Derrida and Foucault). These structures are the constructed epistemological boundaries that we see in the classification between emotions and thought, ideas and theories. In a sense, postmodernism attempts to cross these boundaries to create a more fluid reality – where epistemological borders between art, beliefs and science can be crossed.

I way of looking at it:

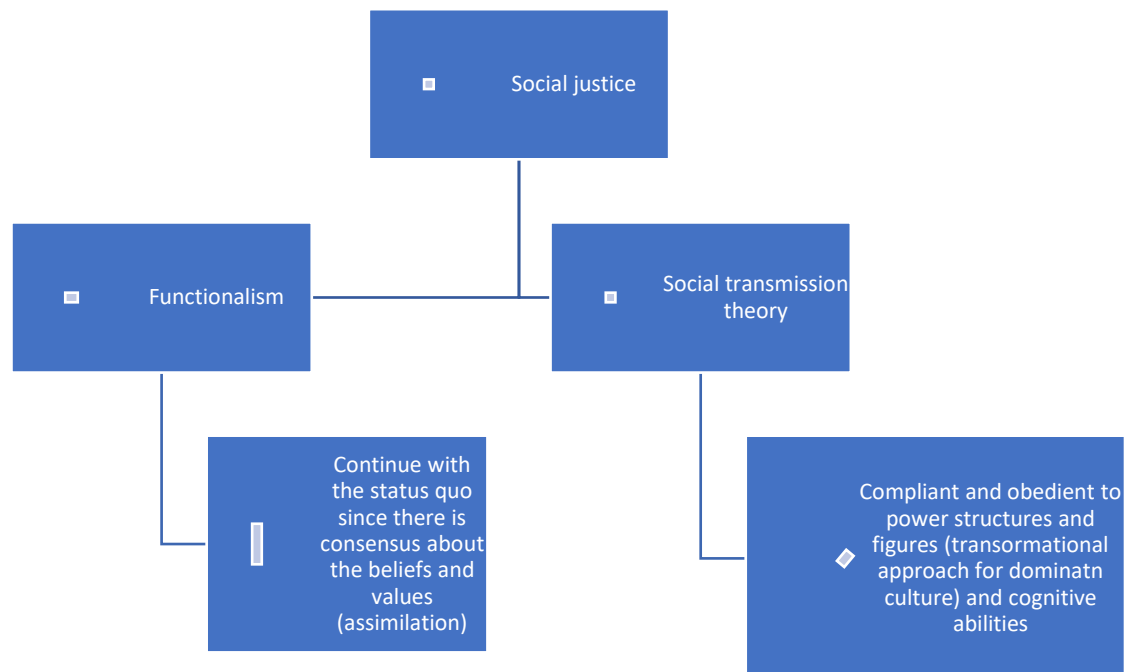
The crossing, however, of epistemological borders is not an attempt to break the rules that established these borders. Instead, the crossing is a way of permitting access to another epistemological field (e.g., from art to science) – much like a passport allows you to cross international borders – and permission is granted based on a principle of social justice.

The principle of social justice

Social justice can be seen as the principle upon which postmodernism crosses epistemological boundaries. Social justice allows this crossing by “Maintenance and replication of the socio-economic and political through transmission of the dominant group’s desirable cultural traditions, beliefs, and values from one generation to the next” (Sommers, 2014:74). The principle of social justice acknowledges that...

inequities in society are inherent and, in many ways, unavoidable.

Where does this principle of social justice come from?



So, theories used in education should be judged, evaluated from this principle. Social justice education theories maintain that schools should serve as sites of democracy with all its inherent ideological, cultural, religious, and social diversity, and should serve to work toward social justice, a significant signpost of democracy.

The following theories abide by this principle (Sommers, 2014):

- Critical theory
- Critical race theory

- Postmodern theory
- Post-structural theory
- Feminism
- Multicultural education

Therefore, to cross an epistemological border within a postmodernist era, the key idea is to maintain the status quo by not changing the current structures, values and beliefs – much like traveling abroad...